

Kamma, Rebirth and Transcendence: A Top-Down View of the Buddhadhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 52:17

Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa. Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammāsaṃbuddhassa.

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed, noble and fully self-awakened one.

In the last talk I was talking about the way our cultural way of looking at things through science or scientism and through our romantic understanding of life and through psychotherapy tends to distort the teaching of the Buddha. And I boiled it down, this teaching, I boiled it down to ethics and transcendence.

If you look at what's happening from a science point of view, it's easy to understand that you're looking upwards through matter. And matter begins to create chemicals, chemicals, some sort of bio-life. And so it all looks very clear, that consciousness and all that appears as part of that process, that upward process of evolution. So it's quite understandable that that would make sense to somebody brought up in that sort of scientific tradition.

If you've been brought up in a religious tradition, one of the Christian traditions or Islam or Judaism or Hinduism, then, of course, you're looking at it from a slightly different way. You're looking at it down. You're looking down and seeing how everything slowly descends to the material base. So that's what I want to try and do this evening, to give you a different perspective.

And the first thing is to be clear about what the Buddha means by transcendence, what he's pointing to. So in the last talk I also mentioned some of these quotes. The one where people feel that he's been most clear is this one. It says there is a sphere or a dimension where there's no earth, no water, no fire, no air. Now those of course are your four great elements by which the mind contacts matter. So when you're looking at the pain in your knees, it'll either be fiery or it'll be heavy and thick.

So remember that when the Buddha talks about the world, the all, he's not talking about the objective world of science. He's talking about the way we experience it. The world that we're actually manufacturing. He's always talking from that angle. It's not that he denies that the world out there exists, but he's saying that from the point of view of liberation, it's the world that we're actually creating that we've got to be liberated from.

And he says there's no base consisting of space, consciousness, nothingness, perception, non-perception. This refers to these higher *jhānic* states, which is the most refined place that the mind can get to. It's when

the mind actually stops producing, and there's just the awareness of that space.

And then he says it's neither this world or another world, nor both, neither sun nor moon. So he is saying that there isn't a physical world where this transcendent place is. He says there's no coming and going and no staying. So there's no sense of space and there's no sense of time. There's no ceasing, no uprising. So it's without change. This place is without change.

So remember those three characteristics, *dukkha*, *anicca* and *anattā*. So there's no suffering there, it's *aduk kha*. There's no impermanence there, it's *nicca*. And of course there's no self there, there's no sense of a self. It's a non-dual state.

It's not fixed, it's not movable. So it's not fixed and movable. It's coming from our position that everything has a place and you can move most things. Everything changes. But there, there's nothing. So you can't talk about something being fixed or movable. And it has no support. So this means everything in this world is dependent on something else. Nothing arises of itself. There's no existent. But this is a place where it doesn't need anything at all. So he's obviously pointing to something which is quite other than what we're experiencing. And that's what we mean by transcendence. And he says, just this is the end of suffering.

So then, of course, there's the other famous one that people quote. There exists—so the word *ati*—there is the not born, the not compounded, the not created, the not conditioned. But then he goes on to a second verse which he says, if there were not this not born, not compounded, not created, not conditioned, there'd be no escape. No escape could be discerned from the born, the compounded, the created and the conditioned. And then the final verse says, but because there is this not born, then there is obviously an escape. So again, he's talking about something which is of another nature, another dimension.

And the other final one which I brought up the last time was this question of where do earth, water, fire and air find no footing? Remember, somebody asks him where the world comes to an end. So this is the world we're creating. And he says, well, that's the wrong question. You should ask where does it find no footing? So there's nothing destroyed in the process. He himself says the only thing that's destroyed in the process of liberation is greed, hatred and delusion. Everything else remains.

Where are long and short, small, fair, foul? Where are the subject and object wholly destroyed? A sense of object. Remember this non-dual place. If you say there's one, there's a presumption that there may be a two. So that's why this word of non-dual is coined. But of course each system has a different understanding of non-dual. So for the Hindus, non-dual, the non-dual state is to be at one with Brahman. But in the Buddhist tradition, it's to be in this state of *Nibbāna*.

So he says that there is a consciousness which is non-manifestive. Now a consciousness that's manifestive is manifesting through the six senses. The five basic physical senses and the mind. Mind, heart, emotions and thoughts. So he said it's non-manifestive. So it's without boundary. So boundaries are created by

phenomena, by objects, by things. So there's nothing there. That's what he's saying. And it's all directions full of light. So consciousness. You can take that as either a state of light or a brightness as if you were inside the bulb, or you can take it as a state of pure awareness.

And he says here's where this earth, water, fire and air, so the physical nature, our physical nature, finds no footing. He says it's where all these opposites, long and short, small and great and so on, subjects and objects are wholly destroyed. They don't exist there.

So now we have this, if we keep the idea of something that's transcendent. Now, what doesn't the Buddha talk about? What won't he actually talk about?

So there were these ten questions that were, I suppose, the obsessions of the age, really. So the first one is, is the world eternal? Is the world not eternal? Is the world infinite? Is the world finite? Is the soul the same as the body? So if it is, then you would be an annihilationist because when the body dies, you go as well. Soul here would be your mind rather. And is the soul different from the body? In which case, the soul would separate from the body and you'd be an eternalist.

So there were these two opposites at the time of the Buddha. You've got the Brahmins and the Jains who said the soul was released, the *jīva* was released into a heavenly state or at one with Brahman. And there were the materialists who said that was it. When you're dead, you're dead.

And then the last four were concerning somebody who was fully liberated. So does the *Tathāgata* exist after death or does he not exist? And then does he exist and not exist? And then finally, does he neither exist nor not exist? So he's cornered any sort of effort at rational—well, of course, he's silent. And he's silent because the questions are always coming from the point of view of a self. And this is what he says to Vaccha.

And then he says his usual thing. He says they regard feeling as self, perception as self, volitional formations as self, consciousness as self or self as possessing consciousness or consciousness is in self or self as in consciousness. Therefore when the wanderers of other sects ask such questions they give such answers. The world is eternal. They can be very certain about it. But the thing is that he never actually says anything about it. He doesn't make any indication as to whether it is or not. Even he might say, well, for those who don't have a self, there is an eternal. But he just goes mum.

So when it comes to those sorts of questions about the world and things like that, he's quite—he doesn't go there. But we'll come to something else in a minute. We'll come back to that.

The next thing that we might ask, but it never seems to occur in the scriptures is, why does this occur in the first place? Where does this *satipaṇṇā* or as the Abhidhamma would put it this *nibbānic* element in us or as the Mahāyāna would point to it as say Buddha nature, where does it come from? Why has it come here? Where did it all begin? So those sorts of questions—the relationship of this *Nibbānadhātu* and how it's come here—again it's never broached. I don't know of a question that comes up in the scriptures to do

with that.

And it's the same with the relationship that our individual *Nibbānadhātus* have with each other. So presumably there's lots of Arahants whose *Nibbānadhātus*, this element, this Buddha nature, is somewhere and do they communicate? Do they communicate? Do they know whether the last perfectly enlightened person is next door or upstairs? So all that area, it just doesn't come up for discussion. It just doesn't arise.

But, of course, other, like the Hindus, tried to work something out for that. And so as you become liberated in the Hindu tradition, where you get *moksha*, freedom, of course, your *ātman*, your self, big self, goes back into Brahman. You become Brahman. So, in that sense, you've got this idea that Brahman, who's neuter, by the way, he's neither male nor female, bursts into all these different *ātman*s, and then they've got to find their way back to him. So in other words, they're trying to answer this question, but it never comes up in the scriptures. And the Buddha never approaches it. So that's the end of that. So it's just knowing that Buddhism doesn't have a monopoly on all truth, that's all.

Now, some would say that they're known as *avyākata* questions. *Avyākata* just means not determined. So he's just not spoken about it. But maybe there's something that is forever unknowable. Just to be able to accept that these sorts of questions are actually unknowable. And that may be one reason why the Buddha kept himself strictly to this particular teaching of liberation.

He does say in one place where he points to the person he's with and he says, or to the monks he's with, he says, you see all the leaves in this forest. He says, well, it's like I know all this, but I've only given you a clump of leaves which you need in order to be liberated. Because you don't know where that was put in later.

Because in the—thank heavens it doesn't say it in the scriptures, but in the *Visuddhimagga*, which is the medieval work of a Buddhādāsa, they describe the qualities of a Buddha, by which time, of course, he's grown to this sort of superhuman, just amazing, beyond human. And they say that he's omniscient. What they mean by that is if he bends his mind towards anything, he'll know the answer. And one thing he knows is that the world is flat. That's a killer, isn't it? So you say, okay. So you have to recognise that there's some messing about here.

So that's something he doesn't talk about. And just to go back a step in a way, just to the origins of the universe, again, there's no effort to do that. There is this peculiar discourse, the *Aggañña Sutta*, in which he lays out a certain creation myth but it's obviously a satire. I mean most people see it now as a satire.

It starts off with him having a talk with this man called Vaseṭṭha. Once the Lord was staying at Sāvattthī at the mansion of Migāra's mother in the East Park. And at that time, Vaseṭṭha and Bhāradvāja were living among monks, hoping to become monks themselves. And in the evening, the Lord rose from his secluded meditation and came out of the mansion, started walking up and down in the shade. Vaseṭṭha noticed this

and he said to Bhāradvāja, Friend, Bhāradvāja, the Lord has come out and is walking up and down. Let's go and approach him. We might be fortunate enough to hear a talk on Dhamma with the Lord himself. Yes, indeed, said Bhāradvāja. And they went up to the Lord, saluted him and fell into step with him.

And then the Lord said to Vasetṭha, Vasetṭha, you two are Brahmins born and bred and you have gone forth from the household life to the homeless life from Brahmin families. Do not the Brahmins revile and abuse you? Indeed, Lord, the Brahmins do revile and abuse us. They don't hold back with their usual flood of reproaches. What kind of reproaches do they fling at you? Lord, what the Brahmins say is that the Brahmin caste is the highest caste. Other castes are base. The Brahmin caste is fair. Other castes are dark. Brahmins are purified. Non-Brahmins are not. The Brahmins are the true children of Brahmā, born of the mouth of Brahmā, created by Brahmā, heirs of Brahmā. And you, you've deserted the highest caste and gone over to the base caste, these shavelings, petty ascetics, servants, dark fellows, born of the Brahmā's foot. It's not right, it's not proper that you should mix with such people. So this is the way the Brahmins abuse us, Lord.

Then Vasetṭha, tell the Brahmins they have forgotten their ancient tradition when they say that, because we can see Brahmin women, the wives of Brahmins, who menstruate and become pregnant, have babies and give suck, and yet these womb-born Brahmins talk about being born of the Brahmā's mouth. These Brahmins misrepresent Brahmā. They tell lies. They earn much demerit.

And then he goes into exactly what happens at the end of the world. So at the end of the world, you can't have all beings destroyed because then that would be the end of *kamma*. And it would suggest that some beings are just not going to make it. So at the end of a world cycle, everybody gets shunted into this highest realm, the Ābhāssvara Brahma. And of course, there were questions asked about this by later commentators. How could this be? Because to get up there you've got to be in the highest of *jhānas* and be pretty pure. So the explanation was that everybody's been around this *saṃsāra* so many times that they must have hit one of these *jhānic* states, and the good *kamma* would come just at that moment and they'd be up in the Ābhāssvara realm.

And this, of course, saved this whole idea of realms from bringing an end to *kamma*. But it also suggests, of course, that everybody, all beings, will eventually be liberated, no matter how many world cycles they have to go through.

Anyway, they're all up there now. And they lived there for a very long time. And having passed away, they were mostly born into this world. And they dwell mind-made, feeding on delight, self-luminous, moving through the air, and glorious. Now at that time there was just one mass of water and all was darkness. So this is often a creation myth. Out of the chaos, the Greek chaos, which was this darkness. Out of nothingness, the Christian idea of everything comes out of nothingness. Even science, the big bang—where does it come from? So just out of this massive water of all darkness, blinding darkness, neither moon nor sun appeared, no constellations or stars, night and day, there was no male or female.

And sooner or later, after a very long period of time, savoury earth spread itself over the waters where those beings were, and it looked just like the skin that forms over hot milk as it cools. It was endowed with colour, smell and taste. It was the colour of fine ghee or butter and it was very sweet, like pure wild honey. And then some being with a greedy nature said, no, what can this be? And he tasted the savoury earth and of course he gets a craving for it. And everybody else says, well, what about that? And they get into it. And the result was, of course, their self-luminosity disappeared. The greed destroyed their self-luminosity.

And so then as they get more and more greedy, this beautiful skin of earth begins to disappear. And fungus grows up, which is just like that, but it's fungus. And then there's like a mushroom. Then creepers appear, shooting up like bamboo. And all the time, their luminosity and their heaviness, they're moving towards becoming more and more material.

And then finally rice appeared in open places, free from powder, free from husk, fragrant, and clean-grained. And as they collected this, their bodies became coarser still, and their looks became greater. The difference in their looks became greater. And then females developed female sex organs, and males developed male organs, and the women became excessively preoccupied with men, and the men became preoccupied with the women, and owing to their excessive preoccupation with each other, passion was aroused, and their bodies burnt with lust.

And later, because of this burning, they indulged in sexual activity, and those who saw them indulging threw dust, ashes, and cow dung at them, crying, "Die, you filthy beasts! How can you be doing such things to one another?" And just as today in some districts when a daughter-in-law is led out, some people throw dirt at her, some ashes and some cow dung, without realising they're repeating an ancient observance. So I don't know where that comes from. Must have been one of those things you did at the marriage.

So it gets worse and worse. And then finally, because of all the immorality, they decide to get somebody who would show anger, would censure people, would banish those who deserve to be banished. And so that was the first king, the people's choice, Mahāsammata. So then you get the idea of kingship coming in. And then because of that, a whole level of society was created – the warrior caste, the Khattiya, and he was also called Rājā, which means he gladdens others with Dhamma. I don't think he does. These are just glosses.

Anyway, evil things appeared, such as taking what is not given, and all that, and then he did the banishments. And then there were people who said, enough of this, and they became very pure, and they lived out in the forest, and these were the Brahmins. Others, of course, who couldn't meditate, couldn't handle the meditation and the seclusion, began to adopt various trades. And then finally there were those who, the Sudda, they are base who live by the chase. So slowly but surely the four castes appeared.

But the whole discourse ends with... "The verse was rightly sung," he said, "and this too is true. The warrior caste, the Khattiyas, are best among those who value the clan." So it becomes an expression of how we've got to this place, the four castes, but by way of ethics. So we're always coming back to ethics.

So as to the question of creation, where we came from and all that, that also is not answered. So again, we have to accept that there are things that maybe are just simply unknowable. But one thing we do know is that we are here, right? We actually are existing or becoming in this very present moment.

If we consider this Nibbāna Dhātu descending, now this was later taken up by the Mahāyāna in the Yogācāra school of the Tathāgatagarbha, which meant the embryo of the Buddha. So the embryo of the Buddha, meaning that within us which is deluded comes down to find its own true nature, enters into this psychophysical organism, and then through the practice becomes the Tathāgata. So Tathāgata means "come there" or "gone there" – this "there" of course is that place of transcendence. So probably the best translation of that is "the one who has transcended" or "the transcendent one," and this is how the Buddha referred to himself, the Tathāgata.

Now, this Nibbāna Dhātu finds itself... I'll keep referring to it from now on as just Buddha nature. It's simpler. This Buddha nature finds itself in this psychophysical organism. And in the Buddha's teachings, there are these three bodies. So again, this was developed out of the basic scriptures, the Pali scriptures, the early scriptures, and it was developed out of it. These different strands of understanding were developed from those bases.

So my teacher, Dr. Ewa Tadama in Birmingham, said to me that everything the Mahāyāna says about their teachings you'll find the kernel of it, you'll find something of that within the basic scriptures of Pali, the early scriptures.

So these three bodies are the Dharmakāya, so that's the Buddha, the Buddha nature. There's the Sambhogakāya, the body of bliss, and that's your mental body. And then there's the Nirmāṇakāya, the body of apparition, or the body that's made, this physical body that we find ourselves in. So, psychophysical.

So, in Buddhist understanding, these two things are quite separate. Although they're melded together at this level of being, they separate at death. And then you have this rebirth into different realms, which we'll come to towards the end of the talk.

So, just to remember that process where the Tathāgatagarbha, the embryo of the Buddha, the Buddha nature comes down in a state of not knowing. So remember, it's not a culpable state. It's not a culpable state, ignorance. It's just basically not knowing. And the mistake is made of believing itself to be this psychophysical organism it finds itself in. And then it seeks happiness. It's as simple as that.

And in seeking happiness, it begins to manipulate the world. So the more it has, the happier it feels, the more secure it feels – more money, friends, all that. And of course then you have to protect it, so that's where your aversion comes, your hatred to anybody who undermines what you have. And if the person's bigger, then of course you run for it.

So remember, those are your three basic attitudes that arise from delusion: acquisitiveness, aversion and

fear. And from that, of course, because of those attitudes, we act in the world and create habits. And these habits are unwholesome and they have unwholesome results. Both inwardly, they create agitation and all the rest of it. And outwardly, of course, they create situations which aren't good for us – war for a start.

So coupled with that of course there is the wisdom factor which grows as you begin to see how we create suffering for ourselves, and then the other side of our nature begins to manifest which is the love, the compassion, the sympathetic joy, courage, gratitude and all the rest of it.

So you could say that the process that we're undergoing is moving away from the effects of that delusion towards the effects of wisdom. And so we're coming back, we're coming back to that original mistake. And that original mistake we call the self. It's an identity that we manufacture with the psychophysical organism we find ourselves with.

And that's our practice – our practice is to begin to discriminate, begin to discern those things that bring us suffering and those things that don't, that bring us happiness, a real happiness. And then as you come back into yourself, you come to this business of the observer, and of course that's where the initial problem lies, because it's through the observer that you enter into the world that we're creating.

I was going to also talk about... just to reinforce this idea that the Buddha only teaches ethics. Ethics, you can translate ethics as – ethics means relationship. So it's how you're relating. Morality tends for us to mean wrongdoing and stuff. So it has a more restricted meaning, I think, in our minds – Ten Commandments and all that. But ethics is just about relationship.

Now, we are in relationship all the time. We're in relationship with our food, we're in relationship to the door when we open it, relationship with people. Our whole lives are an act of relationship. And, of course, there's the relationship with ourselves, too. So ethics is really about how we relate – how, if we get it wrong, it can create suffering, and how, if we get it right, it creates happiness.

So once we've grasped that, that the whole of our lives is a relationship, then of course we want to do something about it. We want to make sure that we get it right.

If you remember when the Buddha was born, this holy man, this sage saw him and determined that either he was going to be a world conquering monarch or a fully self-enlightened being, and he began to cry. And when they asked him why he was crying, he said well, I won't be around to see which one he'll go for, but the accent was that he would actually become fully self-liberated.

Running in the scriptures, you get this alter ego of the world-conquering monarch. And in one of the scriptures, the old monarch is dying. The wheel treasure, so you have to imagine this wheel in the sky. And when that begins to disappear, it's time for the king to move on and to leave it to his son.

And so when the son takes – just before the son takes rule, he asks him, "Sire, what is the duty of the Ariyan wheel-turning monarch?" And he says, "It is this, my son. Yourself depending on the Dhamma,

honouring it, revering it, cherishing it, doing homage to it and venerating it. Having the Dhamma as your badge and banner, acknowledging the Dhamma as your master, you should establish, guard, ward and protect, according to the Dhamma, for your own household, your troops, your nobles and vassals, for Brahmins and householders, towns and country folk, ascetics and Brahmins, for beasts and birds. Let no crime prevail in your kingdom. And to those who are in need, give property. And whatever ascetics and Brahmins in your kingdom have renounced the life of sensual infatuation and are devoted to forbearance and gentleness, each one taming himself, each one calming himself, and each one striving for the end of craving, from time to time you should go to them and consult them as to what is wholesome and what is unwholesome, what is blameworthy and what is blameless, what is to be followed and what is not to be followed, what action will in the long run lead to harm and sorrow, and what to welfare and happiness. Having listened to them, you should avoid evil and do what is good. That is the duty of an Ariyan world-turning monarch."

So the son says, "Yes, sire. Thank you very much." And, of course, he becomes the king. Then, of course, he doesn't do that. Things went wrong, and the wheel slipped from its position. And so this man came to the king and said, "Sire, you should know that the sacred wheel treasure has disappeared." That's bad news.

"At this the king was grieved and felt sad, but he did not go to the royal sage, or ask about the duties of a wheel-turning monarch. Instead, he ruled the people according to his own ideas, and being so ruled, the people did not prosper so well as they had done under the previous kings who performed the duties of a wheel-turning monarch."

Then the ministers, counsellors, treasury officials, guards and doorkeepers, and the chanters came to the king and said, "Sire, as long as you rule the people according to your own ideas, and differently from the way they were ruled before under previous world-turning monarchs, the people do not prosper so well." So then they say to him, "Sire, there are ministers in the realm, including ourselves, who have preserved this knowledge of how a wheel-turning monarch should rule. Ask us, Your Majesty, and we will tell you."

So he asks them and he consults them and all that, and then having listened to them the king established a guard of protection but he did not give property to the needy, and as a result poverty became rife. And with the spread of poverty a man took what was not given – thus committed what was called theft. They arrested him and brought him to the king saying, "Your majesty, this man took what was not given, which we call theft."

And the king said to him, "Is it true you took what is not given, which is called theft?" "It is, it is, Majesty." "Why?" "Your Majesty, I have nothing to live on." Then the king gave him some property, saying, "Look, with this, my good man, you can keep yourself, support your mother and father, keep a wife and children, carry on a business and make gifts to ascetics and Brahmins, which will promote your spiritual welfare and lead to a happy rebirth with pleasant results in the heavenly sphere." "Very good, Your Majesty," replied the man.

And the exact same thing happens to another man. And the people heard the king was giving away property to those who took what was not freely given. "Supposing we were to do likewise." And then another man took what was not given and they brought him to the king and the king asked him why he'd done it. He replied, "Sire, I've nothing to live on."

And the king thought, "If I give property to everybody who takes what is not given, this theft will increase more and more. I'd better make an end of him, finish him off once and for all and cut his head off." So he commanded his men, "Bind this man's arms tightly behind him with a strong rope, shave his head closely, lead him to the rough sound of a drum through the streets and squares and out through the southern gate, and there finish by inflicting the capital penalty and cut off his head." And they did so.

And hearing about this, the people thought, "Now let us get sharp swords made for us, and then we can take from anybody what is not given, we will make an end of them, finish them off, cut their heads off." And so having procured sharp swords they launched murderous assaults on villages, towns and cities, went in for highway robbery, killing their victims by cutting off their heads. So you can see once the rot sets in, you're just not going to get out of it.

And so it goes on and then finally the Dhamma monarch is re-established after many generations, five thousand years. And it gets worse because what happens is as people get more and more unethical, they lose their lifespan and they get down to... a time will come when children of these people have a lifespan of ten years. And the girls will be marriageable at five years old. And with them, these flavours will disappear: ghee, butter, sesame oil, molasses and salt. So it gets worse and worse and worse.

But again, it's just this idea that morality, ethics really, is what it's all about. And actually, that was the teaching of that Axial Age. If you look across to Lao Tzu and the Tao, and Moses, the Ten Commandments, and Socrates, all the same age. Socrates also said desire was the problem. You'll see there's an awakening of mankind to this idea that you do unto others as you would have them do unto you. That was the big message of what's known as the Axial Age. So anyway, that's the Buddha's teaching. It's about ethics.

So now we come to this knotty problem about rebirth. So that's another question that the Buddha doesn't answer. He doesn't tell us how the process takes place. Now, we hear of people with near-death experiences, especially on operating tables where they come out and they can actually tell what's actually happened during the operation. We also know that people have out-of-body experiences and see this whirling tunnel through which they go, sometimes into another realm. But none of that is in the Pali scriptures. The question of... nobody said to the Buddha, "Yeah, but how does it happen?"

So it's just that there's a teaching about there are different realms. And the basic one is, of course, the six realms. So the purgatorial realm, which is sometimes called hell realm. But hell, according to Dante, I mean, that's "abandon all hope, ye who enter here." There's nothing eternal in the world, according to Buddhism, so it's much better to think of it as purgatory, where you purge your sins and get rid of all your bad *kamma*. And there are various levels of that, the worst one being the Avīci hell, of course, where those

who've been extremely cruel go, which is the opposite of the Buddhist teaching about compassion.

Then there's the animal realm – born an animal. There's the human realm, which is ours. The hungry ghosts, they're the ones who are driven by greed.

There's the angry devas—they're the clever people who are driven by anger, jealousy, all that sort of stuff. And then finally there's the deva realm, which is where beings are happy.

So you've got these six realms. And of course, what tends to happen is the relationship between what we experience as human beings extended into other realms of existence. So if you're in a deep depression and you don't see a way out of it, you're despairing, you're obviously in a hell realm. If you get drunk and do all sorts of daft things, then you're obviously in an animal realm. There's the human realm, of course. When we're craving for stuff and we can't just stop going for those biscuits, then you're a hungry ghost. And when we're getting angry and trying to get the best of somebody, we're in the angry deva realm. And then finally when we're happy and peaceful and wandering about the meadows here, then we're in the deva realm.

So there's always that connection between what we as human beings can experience and the cosmology that Buddhism talks about. So those are your basic things, but in the Abhidhamma it gets much more refined because then they talk about all these various realms to do with also with the jhānas. So the whole cosmology is built up into this huge idea of vast different realms, many realms all over the place—whether they exist or not is a moot point, of course.

So in order to get into these realms, of course, you've got to be reborn. You can't annihilate. If you annihilate, you don't get reborn. And therefore, you'll never experience these realms. So when it comes to rebirth, which is very difficult for us, because if you've been brought up a Christian or a Muslim or something like that, then it's easier. But for people who've been brought up in a more secular way, it's very difficult to actually just open up to the idea.

There's been lots of studies on it. I mean, what's his name? Ian Stevenson has written *Twenty Cases Suggestive of Reincarnation*. And there's also stuff on the website. I've actually put a clip on our website. So there's no way it's ever going to be proven scientifically. There's not going to be an fMRI scan of somebody being reborn. In the medieval ages, they would weigh a body before it died and then weigh it again after it died to see how much the soul weighed. And they were always upset because it didn't have any weight. There was no change. We're trying to prove that something which is transcendent actually exists. So we can forget about trying to prove whether there's rebirth or not.

But one thing is for sure, that when you start reading the discourses, it comes across all the time. You can't read the discourses without including rebirth. They don't make sense in terms of the whole law of kamma. So even in the Buddha's awakening we talk about the three knowledges that came to him where he remembered his past lives, which showed him how he came to be fully liberated and what was the driving

force of that was his ethics.

And then he saw other beings moving from realm to realm, driven again by their ethics. So what had been just a personal law, he saw as a universal law. And then, of course, the third knowledge was that he himself was purified of all his defilements. So he goes right back to the—in the tradition, it's right back there to the awakening—of the whole thing about rebirth. And Bhikkhu Bodhi has written a monograph on it. And I've taken his ideas from there.

And the question he asks is, well, does it make sense? Is it intelligible? Does it make any sense in terms of the Dharma? Well, you can see that without the idea of rebirth, how do you ever resolve the actions that you've made? And this also moves into the idea that the universe has some sort of moral equilibrium, has some sort of moral resolution to it.

You might say that's more of an intuitive thing, that eventually whatever harm somebody has done has to be mended in some way, has to be ameliorated, has to be compensated for. So you have to forget the idea of punishment. It's to do with results. You do something wrong and there will be a result within your psychophysical organism. And the result will reverberate back to this Buddha nature when it wakens up and realises, oh, I've done something wrong. I'm now in a world, my world, the world I'm creating, which is full of guilt, full of remorse, full of shame.

And of course the world then mirrors back to you. So if you're very sarcastic you find yourself being a bit lonely sometimes. So the way you behave also affects other people and they mirror your behavior back to you by the way they behave towards you.

There's a feeling that there must be some work out, because as we know, in the ordinary world as we see it, people get away with murder, and people who do wonderful things are never acknowledged. They might end up in a bad way too. Remember that poor man who went out to help the business in the Middle East, and they caught him and they shot him out in the desert somewhere—Jihadi John, one of the ISIS people. Do you remember that awful thing? He'd gone out to help a Muslim charity and he got out to the east. You might remember it and they showed him on YouTube and just before he was to be shot. So there's that and that makes you think, well, how does that work out?

Some people think that just because you're born or you go through something terrible in this life, that this is because you did something terrible in the past life. I think you've heard me talk about this tale which comes up in the Dhammapada, where there's a ship going across the ocean and it suddenly stops. It doesn't move. And the captain goes and consults these monks who are on board. And they sit down in deep contemplation. And they go to him and say, well, it's your wife. In the past life, she killed all these dogs. I can't remember what it was now. Dogs or something. So the only way it's going to move is to get rid of your wife, you see. So he throws her overboard. And of course, the ship moves on. There's one way to get rid of your wife.

So you've got these stories coming from the scriptures of moral retribution. So there's the feeling that maybe to make sense of the whole karmic law, there has to be some equilibrium, some way in which things are worked out. So that's an intuitive thing. Either you've got it or you've not.

And of course in terms of the whole process that we're in, which is about liberation, and about the—you might call it a categorical imperative in the Buddha's teaching—that all beings are heading towards liberation, and they will make it. So there is in us this Buddha nature which is indestructible. That's the point. It's immortal. It doesn't die. It's not born. And so it will keep being reborn until it finds that it doesn't have to be reborn anymore and finds itself in a blissful place which we call Nibbāna.

And of course there are two descriptions of what that is. In Theravāda the Self-Enlightened One just goes into Nibbāna, full stop. Nothing more is said. But in the Mahāyāna, you're drawn out to help other beings. And therefore you reappear in your bliss body in different realms. So the whole idea of kamma fits in with that basic idea that all beings are destined to be liberated one way or the other.

So it's with this rational argument—you see, it's not scientific, it's a rational argument—one might open up to the idea of rebirth. But having said all that, of course, it doesn't matter, does it? Because the Dharma works for us whether we believe it or not. So it's a case of really not coming to a conclusion.

I quote here Bhikkhu Bodhi: the karmic process functions autonomously, without a supervisor or directly, entirely through its own intrinsic power of volitional action. So it's just the law of kamma, there's no need for a god, there's no need for punishment, it just works itself out.

There's a quote here from the Buddha which I'll end with: "The end of the world is to be seen, known and reached by travelling—that I do not say. And yet I do not say that one makes an end of suffering without reaching the end of the world. Rather, in this fathom-long body, with its consciousness and mind, I declare the world, the arising of the world, the ceasing of the world, and the way leading to the ceasing of the world. Just this is the end of suffering."

I can only hope my words have been of some assistance, that they have not confused, and that through your practice you may be liberated from all suffering, sooner rather than later.

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